

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 11-12

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 11

Nita's Walk

THE NEXT MORNING Nita woke me up, while the rest of the camp was still asleep.

“I have a gift for you,” she said. She took her blanket shoes off and tied them to my feet.

“You need the shoes,” she said. I had learned long ago never to refuse a gift.

“*Yakoke*, Nita,” I said, smiling at my little sister. “You are sweet.” Nita ran to the campfire and hid behind her mother.

“Nita, where are your shoes?” her mother asked.

Nita pointed to me.

“She wanted me to have these,” I said. Her mother beamed with pride. I ate my breakfast quickly, then I cut Nita another pair of shoes.

“Here,” I said to her. “Now big brother and little sister both have blanket shoes!”

“I like that!” she said.

Nita stayed near me all day. Once she jumped under my blanket and giggled. The cold was easier to endure with Nita close by.

At sunset the wind blew hard and rattled the ice in the trees. I drew my blanket over my head. Our day’s walk would soon be over, and I was glad.

The shiver came swift and warm. I opened my eyes and Nita smiled at me. As I watched, her face swelled till her lips were puffy and her eyes were tiny slits. She stared at me without moving.

At first I didn't notice the small spider by her nose. It was a tiny black spider and it crawled across her face. I reached out a finger to flick it from her cheek, but my hand went right through her!

Nita was a ghost.

"It is her time," Mister Jonah whispered in my ear.

When I opened my eyes, Nita was still alive, walking beside her mother. We stepped from the road and into the woods. Luke and I gathered wood, while Gabe and my father started the cooking fire.

We all slept close to the fire. Nita slept by her mother and I found a dry spot on the ground next to Luke. When everyone else was asleep, I spoke to him. I had to talk to someone.

"Luke, are you awake?" I whispered.

"Yes," he said.

"Tomorrow will be a bad day."

"How do you know?" he asked.

"I just know," I said. "I am afraid for Nita."

"Can we help her?" he asked.

"No. I don't know how to help her."

"I am your brother, Isaac," Luke said. "Whatever happens, we are strong. We have seen many people die. We are some of the lucky ones. We still have our family."

"You are a good brother, Luke," I said, and drifted off to sleep.

The next morning, Ruth's cries woke everyone. Sometime during the night, Nita had rolled out of her blanket. She now lay covered by a blanket of snow, with only her face showing. I saw the tiny spider crawl across the face of my little sister, Nita.

“No,” Ruth sobbed. “My sweet Nita, my little girl. No!”

My mother ran to help and wrapped Nita in her blanket. Nita did not move. She would never move again.

Ruth's cries carried far beyond our camp, and soon a dozen women circled Nita and her mother. The older women broke bark from the trunks of cedar trees. They burned the bark and waved the smoke over Nita. They sang the Choctaw death song.

No one built a cooking fire that morning.

A soldier rode his horse into camp.

“Time to walk!” he shouted. He looked at Nita and the women.

Another soldier pulled his horse to a stop.

“What’s the hold up?” he asked.

“Another one died,” the soldier said.

“One less to feed,” said the second soldier.

They rode away.

I was glad Nita’s family did not hear the soldiers’ talk. But I had heard them, and Luke and my father heard them. We would never forget what they said.



Chapter 12

Disappearing Daughter

I HAD NEVER SEEN anybody as sad as Ruth and Gabe were that morning. Nobody said a word. Ruth knelt on the ground and wrapped Nita in her blanket. Gabe helped her to her feet and Ruth took the first step, carrying her little girl's body.

Gabe clung to her arm, as if he was afraid of falling. The women followed and the walk began.

I had never seen a parent lose a child before. I was seeing something else, too. I now knew what my parents would feel when I became a ghost. I felt the warm shiver coming.

"No, not now," I said. I closed my eyes tight and shook my head.

"Do not be afraid," a tiny voice said to me. "You are still my big brother." I opened my eyes and Nita stood before me.

"I am sorry," I said. "I wanted to help you."

"You can help me," Nita said. "You can help my mother and father, too. You can make them happy again."

"How can I do that?"

"You can find my sister."

"Your sister?" I asked. "I didn't know you had a sister."

"Ask my father about her," Nita said. She smiled at me and reached for my hand. "He will tell you." Then she was gone.

Nita had another sister? If she was lost, why weren't they looking for her?

I knew this was a secret not even my mother or father knew.

I had to be very careful.

We made camp early that day. Ruth and Gabe traded carrying Nita, and they barely lifted their feet when they walked. Their feet left a sad trail on the road. Sometimes they sang the death song; sometimes they sang *Amazing Grace* in Choctaw. It is our song.

After our corn soup supper, I watched Gabe. I knew it would be easier to talk to him alone. When he stood up to go to the woods, I followed.

"Gabe, can we talk?" I asked.

"Yes, if you want to."

"I want to help."

"What can you do?" he said. I knew he was not listening, not yet.

"I want to help you find your other daughter."

The look on his face changed. He looked almost angry.

"We do not have another daughter," he said. "Do not speak of this!"

"Gabe, I know this is a secret. I have told no one."

"What are you talking about?" he said. I saw that he was no longer angry.

He was afraid.

"Nita told me."

He started crying and moaning. "Go away, please."

"I want to help," I said. "Nita told me about her. Gabe, I have a secret, too.

This is a secret my mother and father do not know."

"What is your secret?"

"I will be a ghost," I told him. "Soon, I think."

Gabe grabbed my shoulder. He turned me around and looked me in the eyes. "I am listening," he said.

"I see ghosts. They tell me things. Nita came to me this morning after she died. She wants me to find her sister. She wants you to be happy again."

"Nita told you this?"

"Yes."

"I cannot talk to you about Nita's sister. Not yet. I need to ask Ruth. Then maybe we can talk."

"What can I tell Nita?" I asked. "You know she won't let this go."

For the first time since Nita died and became a ghost, Gabe smiled. His body shook and his eyes filled with tears, but he was smiling.

"You are right," he said. "She is a determined little girl. Tonight we can talk. All of us, your family, too."

"Yakoke. Gabe, I miss her, too." He patted me on the shoulder and we walked back to camp. I couldn't stop myself from listening as he spoke to Ruth.

"No, no, we cannot do this," Ruth said. He pulled her close and they spoke in whispers, till Ruth looked at me with a question in her eyes.

The wind blew strong that day. The snow swirled in circles and we were blinded by it. As I walked, I looked to my feet and pulled the blanket over my head.

If I walk off the road I'll bump into a tree, I thought. That's how I will know I'm off the road.

When you cannot see, your mind tells strange stories.

Maybe that's how it happens, I thought. That is how I become a ghost. I bump into a tree and icicles fall all around me. I slip and fall. Then one long dagger icicle waits for its turn to fall. Everybody in the world stares at that one giant icicle. They hold their breath. I look at the icicle, too.

I realize I am lying right under it.

"No," I whisper. The icicle responds.

It shakes, but it keeps everybody waiting. It is a very cruel icicle; anybody can see that. Then, as if it has nothing better to do, the icicle falls. I close my eyes. The icicle stabs me in the heart!

"No!" I shouted.

I was in the real world.

"Isaac," my father said, grabbing me. "Are you hoke?"

"Yes. I just had a bad dream while I was walking."

“That’s okay,” he said. “I have been having bad walking dreams all day, too.
Stay strong. This will be over soon.”

Not until I am a ghost, I thought.

But I couldn’t tell him that.

Not yet.